



CANDLES adorn Rob Reiner's star on the Hollywood Walk of Fame. He and his wife were found dead Sunday.

Bass rips response to fires in city, county

'Both sides botched it,' mayor says on podcast. Her remarks are later removed.

By DAVID ZAHNISER

The setting looked almost cozy: Los Angeles Mayor Karen Bass and a podcast host seated inside her home in two comfy chairs, talking about President Trump, ICE raids, public schools and the Palisades fire.

The recording session inside the library at Getty House, the official mayor's residence, lasted an hour. Once it ended, the two shook hands and the room broke into applause.

Then, the mayor kept talking — and let it rip.

Bass gave a blunt assessment of the emergency response to the Palisades and Eaton fires. "Both sides botched it," she said.

She didn't offer specifics on the Palisades. But on the Eaton fire, she pointed to the lack of evacuation alerts in west Altadena, where all but one of the 19 deaths occurred.

"They didn't tell people they were on fire," she said to Matt Welch, host of "The Fifth Column" podcast.

The mayor's informal remarks, which lasted around four minutes, came at the tail end of a 66-minute video added to "The Fifth Column's" YouTube channel last month. In recent weeks, it was replaced by a shorter, 62-minute version — one that omits her more free-wheeling final thoughts.

The exact date of the interview was not immediately clear. The video premiered on Nov. 25, according to the podcast's YouTube channel.

Welch declined to say whether Bass asked for the

[See Bass, A8]

Deep discounts on water for farmland

By IAN JAMES

The water that flows down irrigation canals to some of the West's biggest expanses of farmland comes courtesy of the federal government for a very low price — even, in some cases, for free.

In a new study, researchers analyzed wholesale prices charged by the federal government in California, Arizona and Nevada, and found that large agricultural water agencies pay only a fraction of what cities pay, if anything at all. They said these "dirt-cheap" prices cost taxpayers, add to the strains on scarce water, and discourage conservation — even as the Colorado River's depleted reservoirs continue to decline.

"Federal taxpayers have been subsidi-

dizing effectively free water for a very, very long time," said Noah Garrison, a researcher at UCLA's Institute of the Environment and Sustainability. "We can't address the growing water scarcity in the West while we continue to give that water away for free or close to it."

The report, released last week by UCLA and the environmental group Natural Resources Defense Council, examines water that local agencies get from the Colorado River as well as rivers in California's Central Valley, and concludes that the federal government delivers them water at much lower prices than state water systems or other suppliers.

The researchers

[See Water, A7]



THE PRESIDENT'S chief of staff, Susie Wiles, attends a meeting last week.

Trump aide on defense

White House stands by Wiles as tell-all causes a stir

By MICHAEL WILNER AND ANA CEBALLOS

WASHINGTON — President Trump's chief of staff is defending herself after granting an extraordinarily candid series of interviews with Vanity Fair in which she offers stinging judgments of the president and blunt assessments about his administration's shortcomings.

The profile of Susie Wiles, Trump's reserved, influential top aide since he re-

sumed office, caused a scandal in Washington and prompted a crisis response from the White House that involved nearly every single figure in Trump's orbit issuing a public defense.

In 11 interviews conducted over lunches and meetings in the West Wing, Wiles described early failures and drug use by billionaire Elon Musk during his time in government and mistakes by Atty. Gen. Pam Bondi in her public handling of the Jeffrey Epstein files.

Wiles also acknowledged that Trump had launched a retribution campaign against his perceived political enemies.

"I don't think he wakes up thinking about retribution," Wiles told Chris Whipple, the Vanity Fair writer who has written extensively on past chiefs of staff, "but when there's an opportunity, he will go for it."

Wiles also cited missteps in the administration's immigration crackdown, con-

[See Wiles, A7]

Reiner son faces murder charges in double slaying

He could get the death penalty or life in prison without parole if convicted.

By JAMES QUEALLY, RICHARD WINTON, HANNAH FRY AND GAVIN J. QUINTON

Los Angeles County prosecutors on Tuesday announced murder charges against Nick Reiner, days after his parents — Hollywood legend Rob Reiner and Michele Singer Reiner — were found stabbed inside their Brentwood home.

Prosecutors said they would file two counts of first-degree murder with special circumstances against Nick Reiner. Reiner, 32, also faces a special allegation that he used a deadly weapon, a knife, in the crime, L.A. County Dist. Atty. Nathan Hochman said during a news conference.

"This case is heartbreaking and deeply personal, not only for the Reiner family and their loved ones, but for our entire city," LAPD Chief Jim McDonnell said during the news conference.

With prosecutors alleg-

ing a special circumstance — that Nick Reiner committed multiple homicides — he could face a death sentence or life in prison without the possibility of parole if convicted. Prosecutors have not made a decision on whether to seek capital punishment. That review process can take months, and Hochman has yet to seek death in any case since restoring the office's pursuit of capital verdicts last year.

Los Angeles police responded to the Reiner home in the 200 block of Chadbourne Avenue about 3:40 p.m. Sunday after the couple's daughter found her parents with apparent stab wounds, law enforcement sources confirmed to The Times. Hours later, around 9:15 p.m., authorities caught up with Nick Reiner in Exposition Park near USC and took him into custody.

Reiner is being held without bail at Twin Towers Jail and is considered a suicide risk and was placed under special supervision, a law-enforcement source told The Times. The source spoke on condition of anonymity in order to discuss the confidential matter.

Reiner was scheduled to

[See Reiner, A8]

When love can't cure addiction

Nick Reiner's drug use and mental illness may look familiar to many families.

By CORINNE PURTILL

When Greg heard about the deaths of Rob and Michele Reiner, and the alleged involvement of their son Nick, the news struck a painfully familiar chord.

It wasn't the violence that resonated, but rather the heartache and desperation that come with loving a family member who suffers from an illness that the best efforts and intentions alone can't cure.

Greg has an adult child who, like Nick Reiner, has had a long and difficult struggle with addiction.

"It just rings close to home," said Greg, chair of Families Anonymous, a national support program for friends and family members of people with addiction. (In keeping with the organization's policy of anonymity for members, The Times is withholding Greg's last name.)

"It's just so horrible to be the parent or a loved one of

somebody that struggles with [addiction], because you can't make any sense of this," he said. "You can't find a way to help them."

Every family's experience is different, and the full picture is almost always more complicated than it appears from the outside. Public details about the Reiner family's private struggles are relatively few.

But some parts of their story are likely recognizable to the millions of U.S. families affected by addiction.

"This is really bringing to light something that's going on in homes across the country," said Emily Feinstein, executive vice president of the nonprofit Partnership to End Addiction.

Over the years, Nick Reiner, 32, and his parents publicly discussed his years-long struggle with drug use, which included periods of homelessness and multiple rehab stints.

Most recently, he was living in a guesthouse on his parents' Brentwood property. Family friends told The Times that Michele Singer Reiner had become increasingly concerned about Nick's mental health in recent weeks.

[See Addiction, A8]



RONALDO SCHEIDT AFP/Getty Images

SPACEX LOOKS SKY-HIGH

The Musk-owned rocket firm's IPO could be the largest ever, at least partly driven by a plan to launch orbiting AI data centers. **BUSINESS, A9**

Rain and snow in holiday forecast
Weather center warns of flood and landslide risks and some tough travel conditions. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Weather
Warm inland; windy. L.A. Basin: 71/53. **B5**
Markets **A11**
Opinion Voices **A12**

Boat strike video won't be released
Caribbean footage can be seen by lawmakers but not the public, says Hegseth. **NATION, A5**

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Sticker shock for Obamacare shoppers

As Congress spars over Affordable Care Act subsidies, a fear over premium hikes.

By JULIE APPLEBY

We've been here before: Congressional Democrats and Republicans are sparring over the future of the Affordable Care Act.

But this time there's an extra complication. Although it's the middle of

open enrollment, lawmakers are still debating whether to extend the subsidies that have given consumers extra help paying their health insurance premiums in recent years.

The circumstances have led to deep consumer concerns about higher costs and fears of political fallout among some Republican lawmakers.

According to a KFF poll released in December, about half of current enrollees who are registered to vote said that if their overall health-

care expenses — copays, deductibles and premiums — increased by \$1,000 next year, it would have a "major impact" on whether they vote in next year's midterm elections or which party's candidate they would support.

For those caught in the middle — including consumers and leaders of the 20 states, along with the District of Columbia, that run their own ACA marketplaces — the lack of action on Capitol Hill has led to uncertainty about what to do.

"Before I sign up, I will wait and see what happens," said poll participant Daniela Perez, a 34-year-old education consultant in Chicago who says her current plan will increase to \$1,200 a month from about \$180 this year without an extension of the tax credits. "I'm not super hopeful. Seems like everything is in gridlock."

In Washington, as part of the deal to end the recent government shutdown, a Senate vote was held Thursday on a proposal to extend

[See Obamacare, A11]